

This is an ambitious, yet crowded novel that focuses on the imbalance between those who hold power and those who face its consequences, writes **Amritesh Mukherjee**

POWERFUL and the damned

A republic is only as genuine as the safety it guarantees, and on that count, India remains largely theoretical. Think of the last time you saw a policeman and felt a sense of relief. Are you struggling? You're not alone. The Indian state inherited its police force from an empire that built and cultivated it to intimidate rather than serve, and despite independence, that job description never really changed. Hence, even today, you don't feel reassured by the police — you feel that old, practised urge to avoid them. To skirt around, to never let your path cross theirs.

That imbalance between those who wield power and those who absorb its consequences is at the very core of *Backlash* by Devadas V M, translated by Nandakumar K from Malayalam. Shreedharan Nair is a retired police officer living alone whose house is pelted with stones every night. He doesn't know who or why. To find out, he must revisit his past, his old cases, his old sins, and all the people he wronged along the way. It's in there that the original title finds its meaning — Eru, literally the act of throwing something, a stone in this case.

A stone thrown is never just a stone thrown. As one character lays it out, stone pelting can serve "as punishment," "revulsion and loathing" — to keep "certain people, such as lepers, beggars, and untouchables, at a non-polluting distance," "to emulate and ridicule," "to

hold things in rapid motion," for "vengeance," and as "an act of desperation." Which of these applies to Shreedharan's case remains, for now, a mystery.

Containing multitudes
Indian storytelling runs on myths, legends, superstitions, anecdotes, and Backlash is no exception. For instance, Chatthan, or Kutichathan, appears repeatedly throughout, a mischievous guardian deity from Malabari Hindu folklore, famous, aptly enough, for pelting his victims with rocks. Elsewhere, the novel plays with the instability of storytelling itself; a tale about Narayana Guru gets contested ("I have heard this story told a little differently," someone says, certain it was Chattampi Swamikal), then contested again (a third voice claims it was Adi Shankaracharya). Even as Hindu and Greek mythologies make their appearances, we understand that every story is really several stories under one name.

Backlash moves between themes, historical events, and perspectives. Each chapter has its own small world loosely stitched to the next, the effect closer to a short story collection than a novel proper. Yet across all that range, police brutality remains constant, the central wound of the story. As one character aptly describes a typical investigation journey, "instead of aiming at and hitting the black dot in the middle of a circle, paint a dot where you can hit and then draw a circle around it, right?"

Justice, in this novel as in the world it's inspired by, is seldom anything to do

with guilt or innocence, but rather with power deciding who gets to be guilty. When someone questions their arrest, a policeman shuts them down by invoking Perarivalan, who "has been in prison for nearly thirty years" for former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi's assassination, "for buying a battery". That it has been proven that the same battery was used in the bomb is another matter. "Therefore, don't teach the police who should be arrested in which case, or how many years they should be in prison for."

Shreedharan understands this system because, for a long time, he was the system. Reflecting on his past, he admits how "the wrongs I have done are only those that any policeman would have done. I have turned a blind eye to more atrocities than I can count. I have stood in the witness box and claimed to have seen things I didn't really see. People who should not be seen, who needed to disappear, I have isolated and tethered."

Backlash is a slim novel with an enormous appetite, but ambition and economy don't always make good roommates. The Babri Masjid demolition, the Emergency, the Kashmir insurgency, the 2002 Gujarat riots, and the 26/11 attacks are all crammed alongside social media, communalism, police brutality, superstition, and the many shades of power. The scenes pass by rather than register; we see them, but we seldom feel them.

Ultimately, a stone thrown is never just a stone thrown. By the time the novel ends, the metaphor enlarges — every act of state violence here is its own thrown stone. It may be a fabricated case, a look away, a false witness sworn under oath, a confession yanked out of a locked room, a staged encounter, a boy picked up for the unforgivable crime of his surname.

For most of his career, Shreedharan was the arm doing the throwing, but as the law of physics goes — throw enough stones at enough people, for long enough, and eventually, inevitably, one finds its way back to you.



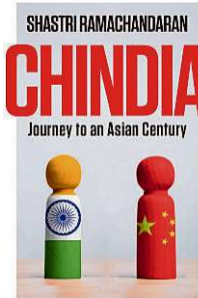
Police brutality remains constant, the central wound of the story. (DH ARCHIVES/FOR REPRESENTATION)

Spotlight on Asia's powerhouses

This is a sensible analysis of how the complex relationship between India and China is likely to shape the destinies of the two countries, writes **AVS Namboodiri**

There are not many countries in the world, at least among the major ones, that have so much in common and yet so many differences as India and China. There are also not many other countries that have engaged each other for so many centuries as modern nations. Countless Indians and Chinese have visited each other's country through the ages and written about their experiences and their views of each other. Yet there is still much more for both countries to know about each other. Veteran journalist and writer Shastri Ramachandran adds to our knowledge of China, of the complex relationship between the two countries, and of India itself in his latest book *CHINDIA*, Journey to an Asian Century.

Shastri is best placed to write about India and China because he has studied China for decades and worked as a journalist in China between 2008 and 2022. He has worked for *China Daily* and *Global Times* in China and was editor of *China-India Dialogue*, published by the China International Publishing Group.



CHINDIA
Shastri Ramachandran
Authors Upfront, pp 442, Rs 895

Clear narrative

The book is divided into five sections in which the theme is introduced ('Scoping out China'), developed through the characters and events ('Elephant and the Dragon', 'India-China Cooperation', 'All the World is a Stage') and resolved with a hopeful vision ('The Asian Century Future'). Knowingly or perhaps unknowingly, the writer has adopted the five-act structure of plays, ideal for narratives that evolve through the words and actions of characters. Shastri presents his story from a distance even when he is close to the events that he reports and comments on. This brings clarity and authority to his narrative.

If dealing with China has been a challenge for diplomats, reporting and writing about the country has posed equally difficult challenges for journalists. Shastri's focus is on India-China relations even when he writes about other countries and other topics. He concludes that China has no option, in the prevalent international climate, but to come to terms with India and create conditions for the two countries to coexist.

India, on its part, should deal with China in more effective ways. One tried and tested approach, he says, is to deal with China exactly as the US does, and not as Washington advises New Delhi to do. Issues such as the boundary dispute and the 1962 war, the intrusions and the skirmishes and stand-offs, including those in the Galwan Valley and Doklam, the pinned visa issue, the mutual visits of leaders, and the growing but unbalanced trade — are slotted, studied and commented on.



Telling perspectives

Many of Shastri's observations are telling and insightful — for instance, his thoughts that China has achieved great progress as a developing economy but as a developing society it has lagged behind. For all the modern infrastructure and industrial development, vast sections of

society are still stuck with customs and practices better suited to periods gone by. He recognises the corruption, the human rights violations and the authoritarian ideas and practices that are part of the system.

The book is also about the world which impacts both India and China and is impacted by them. Apart from the US, Russia and other major countries, South Asian countries and Africa, organisations such as the SCO (Shanghai Cooperation Organisation), and BRICS (platform for strengthening emerging and developing economies) also figure in the analyses. Copious data on trade, the economy, political events, talks and agreements, apart from dates and names, make the book well-rounded, strong on facts and discerning in its interpretation.

This is Shastri's second book on China after *Beyond Binaries: The World of India and China*. *CHINDIA* complements it and will be a valuable aid for scholars, diplomats, researchers and readers.

BOOKRACK

EVERYTHING STARTS AT THE TOP
Srinath Sridharan & Agamjeet Dang
Rupa, pp 224, Rs 595
Drawing on insights from board practitioners, promoters, investors and institutions across Corporate India, the book moves beyond governance theory to address the realities of today's boardroom.

POEMS FOR CIGARETTES
Priyanshu Modi
Invincible, pp 248, Rs 299
With this collection, the author hopes to welcome the readers into a world where poetry becomes a space for introspection, emotional honesty and connection, bringing together his sensibilities as a filmmaker and writer.

TOWER
Bae Myung-hoon and Sung Ryu (translator)
Pan, pp 256, Rs 399
This is a series of interconnected stories set in Beanstalk, a 674-story skyscraper and sovereign nation. Each story deals with how citizens living in the hypermodern high-rise deal with various influences of power in their lives.

THE HAUNTING OF KUNJAMMA P
Shinie Antony
Hachette, pp 224, Rs 699
This is a side-splitting novel about the thin line between belief and delusion, and the diabolical absurdity of being human; a satire at its most unholy and most divine.

THE SIXTEENTH INVASION
Vijay Gogoi
Penguin, pp 344, Rs 699
This is a gripping retelling of two major attempts by the Mughals to conquer the kingdom, and the ingenuity with which the Ahoms resisted, using what nature had bestowed upon them.

Childhood in a world of uncertainty

The decisions Allah Miyan took in creating this world puzzle young Gibran. When a cat makes off with his family's prized black hen (one of two they own in a small village in Awadh), he asks: "Why has Allah Miyan created both cats and hens?" When his madrasa teacher farts after dinner or one of the congregation lets one rip in the Chhoti Masjid during namaz,

Gibran says, "[He doesn't] know why Allah Miyan made this gas so stinky. How fine it would be if it smelled nice. Then no one would need to hold it in while in good company or in mosques. Mosques would become fragrant during namaz." One can't argue with his logic.

Gibran, who narrates Mohsin Khan's Urdu novel *Allah Miyan's Workshop*, which has been recently translated into English by Maaz Bin Bilal, is a dreamer, philosopher (much like his illustrious Lebanese namesake), irreverent scamp, obsessed with flying kites, and not averse to palming off the odd coin when tasked with purchasing things for his el-

ALLAH MIYAN'S WORKSHOP
Mohsin Khan and Maaz Bin Bilal (translator)
Harper, pp 280, Rs 499

ders. He belongs to a literary lineage that includes Twain's Tom Sawyer and Huckleberry Finn and Dickens' various protagonists: adolescent boys who grow up with few comforts but possess a capacity for imagination.



The novel poignantly narrates the tale of an impoverished Muslim family residing in a small village in Awadh. (PIC FOR REPRESENTATION)

The narrator brings to mind a Dickensian boy who grows up with few material comforts but has a great capacity for humour, observes Saudha Kasim

Humour, tinged with sadness

Unlike Twain's yarns, Khan's novel is not full-bore humour — there are scenes of high and low comedy with Gibran at the centre, but as the story is about an impoverished Indian Muslim family in the 21st century, pain and melancholy undergird the narrative.

The book begins with Gibran and his sister, Nusrat, in their tiny house getting ready for namaz on a Friday in winter. As he bathes in ice-cold water in their ramshackle mud bathroom, Gibran asks why Allah keeps Fridays in winter. His Amma is mostly confined to the kitchen where she cooks simple food for the family and is occasionally bedridden when suffering from a migraine attack or other maladies. His father is a member of the

orthodox Tablighi Jamaat movement and leads the calls for prayer at the local masjid. He earns a paltry income from running a small shop.

Gibran and Nusrat, in line with their father's dictates, don't go to a secular school. Instead, they go to the local madrasa where they study the Quran and the Hadith. Their flatulent teacher, the Hafiji, is a strict man who makes the students massage his head and feet, saying 'Come, come, make Allah Miyan happy'. Corporal punishment is the norm for any transgressions: students have to either do humiliating squats or are caned by the 'Cane of Edification'. When Amma asks Gibran's father to get their son and daughter admitted to the government school, he refuses. Unlike their cousins, his older brother Jamil's children, who go to a school in the city. With a father more worried about the eternal afterlife than the here and now, it's little wonder that when he goes away on Tablighi missions, Amma and the children are left to fend for themselves with barely any money, and on the goodwill of friends and neighbours. And when their father doesn't return from one of his trips — they find out he's been arrested on terrorism charges in Gujarat — their small world falls apart, and all that is familiar to Gibran and Nusrat soon vanishes. What follows are the trials and tribulations of children who, instead of being given the care they are due, are forced to leave their childhood behind sooner than they should. In Gibran's case, momentary help comes from an unlikely source, forcing the reader to consider a hitherto unpleasant character in a new light. The book's ending, fittingly, happens around the time of Bakri Eid, the feast of Abraham's sacrifice, when Allah saved a child in recognition of his father's faith.

In his translator's note, Bin Bilal says he cried when reading Khan's novel for the first time. His deep engagement with the text was both as an 'early millennial Indian male' and as a 'sceptical Indian Muslim'. But he insists that anyone reading it will 'connect with the various hues of Gibran's boyhood, as Khan captures with subtlety the innocence, joys, fears, and cruelties in the lives of children in our uncaring adult world'. I couldn't agree more.

READ OF THE WEEK

from targeted advertising to border policing and mass surveillance, data shapes the course of our lives.

Drawing on stories from ancient cave markings and knotted strings to colonial record-keeping and the algorithmic state, Dartmouth professor Roopika Risam reveals how data has always been the seed of power: a technology of control that has shaped civilisations and upheld empires. Provocative, humane and sweeping in scope, *Data Empire* asks us to recognise the power data has always held — and to imagine what resistance looks like in an age defined by it, so that we might remake the modern world for the benefit of all.

